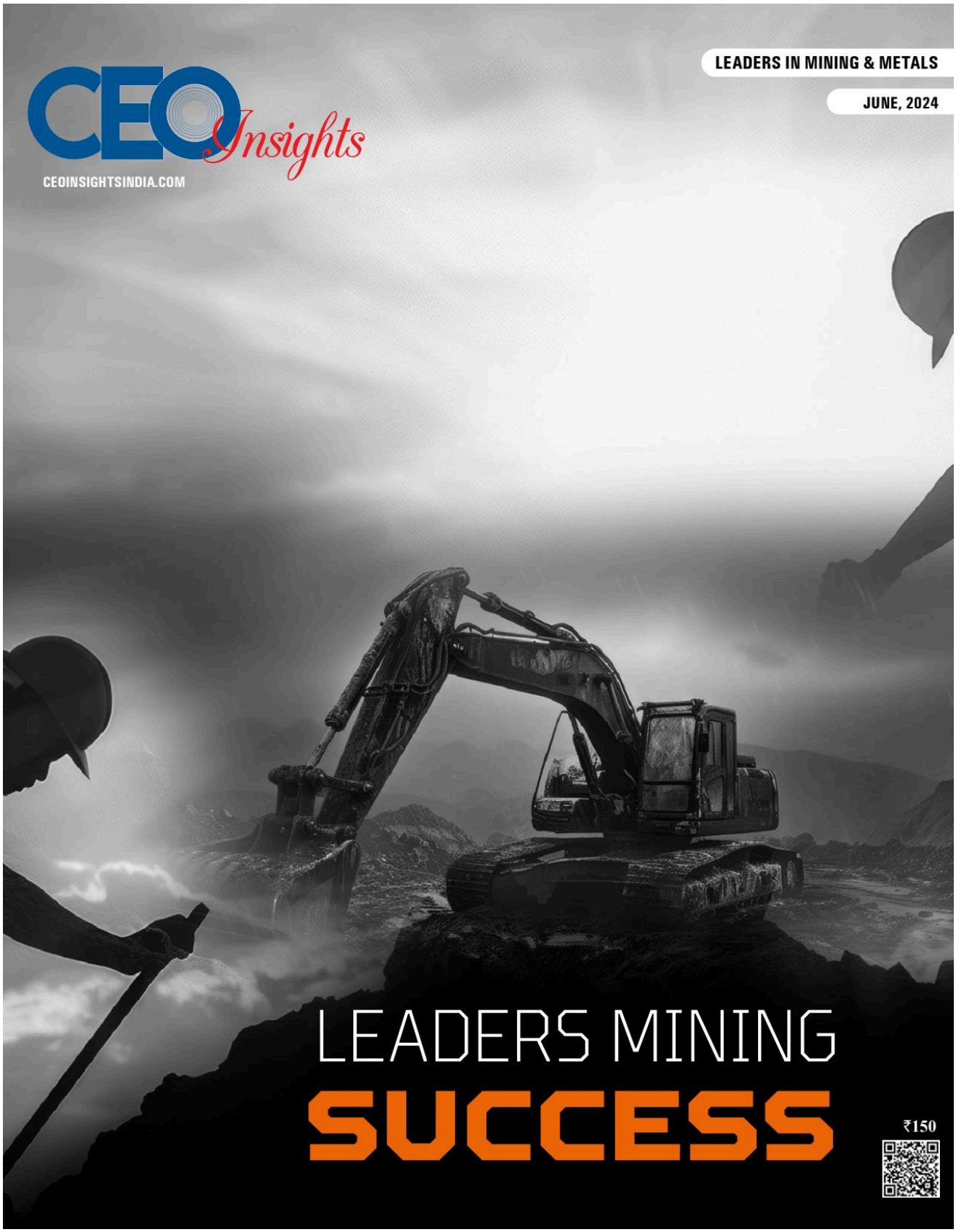
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# Editorial

## Sustainability is an Inevitable Need

The world is facing significant Sustainability challenges due to climate change, equity issues, natural resource consumption and other significant social and environmental concerns. Many organizations worldwide are in the process of integrating Sustainability into their business strategy. On the other hand, several leaders are gazing at the need for sustainability integration as a challenge, confused about the right approach they must adopt. In a recent interview with CEO Insights, Prabodha Acharya, Chief Sustainability Officer, JSW Group, shed light on this dilemma growing organizations face.

As an example, Prabodha puts this challenge in the light of the energy sector. He says, "Take, for instance, the energy sector's ongoing transition. In India, while we still largely depend on fossil fuels, renewable energy sources are increasingly taking precedence. Companies dependent on the fossil fuel economy must now pivot their business strategies to capitalize on this energy transition. The role of environmental sustainability professionals has also evolved from mere compliance managers to becoming strategic architects of sustainable business practices in alignment with global environmental shifts."

He also points out three principal aspects that influence corporate behavior: profit, compliance, and reputation, as well as the effect of Sustainability on them. Profit, or the pursuit of financial gain, is the foundational driver, ensuring that businesses remain financially robust and consistently deliver returns. Compliance, driven by fear of regulatory repercussions, necessitates adherence to legal standards to maintain the right to conduct business. Reputation, the third driver, is about cultivating a positive public image and brand equity. The journey of esteemed Indian conglomerates like JSW, Tata and Birla is a case in point. Due to all these drivers, Sustainability has become a mainstay in business. Investors are increasingly scrutinizing companies to manage sustainability-related risks and opportunities, making it a critical factor in funding decisions. Organizations must see the future through the lens of Sustainability, and the industrial realm demands it.

Sujith Vasudevan
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## EXPERTS TALK




TRANSFORMATIVE LEADERSHIP IN THE AGE OF AI AND CONSTANT CHANGE

**Sankalp Potbhare**
**MD & CEO - Asia Pacific & Japan**
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MANAGING AI INTEGRATION, EMPLOYEE UPSKILLING FOR CHANGE ENVIRONMENT

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**Chief Executive Officer & Director**
**Fiem Industries**

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IN FOCUS

# ADANI'S MUNDRA PORT MAKES HISTORY, LARGEST CONTAINER SHIP DOCKS IN INDIA

Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ) celebrated a significant achievement as Mundra Port received the largest container ship ever to visit an Indian port. The MSC Anna vessel, with an impressive length of 399.98 meters (equivalent to approximately four football fields) and a massive capacity of 19,200 twenty-foot equivalent units (TEU), marked a historic moment in Indian maritime history with its arrival at Mundra Port.

With a draft of 16.3 meters upon its arrival, the MSC Anna can only be accommodated at Adani Ports, Mundra, as no other port in India possesses the capability to berth such a deep-draft vessel. Anticipated to handle an exchange of approximately 12,500 TEUs during its stay, this highlights Mundra Port's adeptness in efficiently managing large-scale cargo operations.

In July 2023, Adani Ports, Mundra, achieved a milestone by docking MV MSC Hamburg, one of the world's longest container ships, boasting an overall length of 399 meters and a capacity of 16,652 TEUs. Its remarkable accomplishments persisted throughout the latter half of 2023.

In October, Adani Ports, Mundra, set a precedent by processing 16 million metric tons (MMT) of cargo within a single month, a first in India. Additionally, its container terminal CT-3 achieved a notable milestone as the first in India to handle 3 million TEUs in a year. Furthermore, in November 2023, the terminal surpassed expectations by handling over 300,000 TEUs in a month, marking the highest throughput ever recorded by any terminal in India.

"Adani Ports, Mundra's evolution into a vital hub for both domestic and international trade is a testament to its strategic planning and world-class facilities. Spanning over 35,000 acres, it is India's largest commercial port, equipped with deep draft and all-weather capabilities. These enable the efficient evacuation of cargo and significantly reduce turnaround times for vessels, making it an attractive destination for major global shipping lines", the release stated. CEO



IN FOCUS

# NASA & INDIA COLLABORATE TO TRAIN ASTRONAUTS FOR SPACE STATION MISSION

Eric Garcetti, the US ambassador to India, announced that NASA will offer advanced training to Indian astronauts for a collaborative mission to the International Space Station. Addressing the 'US-India Commercial Space Conference: Unlocking Opportunities for US & Indian Space Startups' in Bengaluru, Garcetti indicated that the mission might take place either this year or in the near future.

Garcetti also announced the upcoming launch of the NISAR satellite from ISRO's Satish Dhawan Space Center to monitor Earth's resources. NISAR is a joint mission between NASA and ISRO. He emphasized the collaboration between the countries in space exploration and job creation in the sector. Senior officials from both governments and leaders from the commercial space industry participated in the conference.

US Embassy and Consulates in India stated, "US Ambassador to India visited Bengaluru this week to hold a meeting with sector business leaders and entrepreneurs to spotlight robust economic and commercial relations between the United States and India that will transform the coming century, from the seabed to the stars".

Dr. S Somanath, Chairman of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), commended the visionary leadership of both countries. Atul Keshap, President of the US-India Business Council (USIBC), characterized the collaboration as the inception of a new chapter in the space partnership between the United States and India. Alexander Slater, Managing Director of USIBC, underscored the significance of strategic partnerships in fostering innovation.

In Washington, senior defense officials from India and the United States convened for the second annual US-India Advanced Domains Defence Dialogue (AD3), focusing on enhancing space cooperation and exploring potential collaborations with US industry. The dialogue, spearheaded by Vipin Narang of the US and Vishwesh Negi of India, emphasized the commitment to bolster AD3 through consistent working group deliberations and interactions with diverse US defense entities. CEO

IN FOCUS

# ASTER DM HEALTHCARE UNVEILS ₹ 250 CRORE EXPANSION IN BENGALURU




Aster DM Healthcare, one of India's foremost integrated healthcare providers, has unveiled expansion plans for its Aster CMI Hospital, a prominent multispecialty facility in Bengaluru. The expansion will encompass an additional 300,000 square feet of infrastructure, effectively boosting bed capacity from 500 to 850 beds. This strategic move reinforces the company's commitment to Bengaluru, elevating its cumulative bed count across the city to 1602 beds and solidifying its position as a premier healthcare provider. The investment earmarked for this upgrade amounts to approximately ₹ 250 crore, with the anticipated completion slated for FY2027.

Dr Azad Moopen, Founder Chairman, Aster DM Healthcare said, "The current Indian healthcare market looks highly promising, and our efforts will be to increase our footprint in the country dynamically. We are investing heavily in our people, innovation and infrastructure to differentiate ourselves and create long-term value for all our stakeholders. The expansion of Aster CMI Hospital thus solidifies our unwavering commitment to the Indian business. The overall India business EBITDA for Aster DM Healthcare has grown at the rate of 35percent CAGR over the past 5 years, which is reflected in the performance of the EBITDA margin as well. We expect the strong performance to continue in the future, which will be supported by operational leverage on account of brownfield expansion and implementing various cost optimization measures".

The company aims to increase its bed capacity by approximately 1700 beds by FY27, bringing the total number of beds in India to over 6600. This growth will be achieved through both organic and inorganic means, with a focus on becoming one of the top three integrated healthcare providers in India. Additionally, Aster plans to enhance its presence in various geographies by strengthening its network of labs and pharmacies.

The expansion strategy encompasses both brownfield and greenfield projects, such as the upcoming Aster Capital in Trivandrum and Aster MIMS Kasargod, along with augmenting bed capacity in existing hospitals. Additionally, the company is exploring opportunities in potential markets like Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh. The capital allocated for this expansion totals approximately ₹ 1000 crore. CEO



**Vineet Sahni**
Chief Executive Officer & Director
Fiem Industries

**Vineet is a veteran and an inspirational business leader in Automotive Industry with over 35 years of varied leadership experience, especially in 4-Wheel Automotive Lighting Industry. He holds a B.E. in Mechanical from Delhi College of Engineering and PG Diploma in Business Management from MSPI-Delhi.**

# RIGHT TECHNOLOGY & BRIGHT LEADERS: REFORMING THE AUTOMOBILE SECTOR

The Indian economy is largely shaped by the automobile sector. It significantly contributes to the country's GDP and job creation, especially in automotive engineering and technological breakthroughs. Moreover, India is now home to one of the world's biggest and fastest-growing vehicle marketplaces due to its expanding population, rising disposable incomes, and growing urbanization. The credit also goes to the advancements of the automotive technology ecosystem, the automotive supply chain segment for finding sustainable transportation methods, and novel automotive marketing paradigms.

With a profound background in the automotive industry, Vineet Sahni, chief executive officer and director of Fiem Industries Ltd, sheds light on how technology combined with effective leadership is revolutionizing the sector. Having worn several hats over 37 years in the automotive sector, he spent 10 years as the Group CEO of Lumax Group, 14 years with Minda Group of Industries, and two years with Xerox. Below are his insights on the new era that technology has brought to the automotive industry.

**What are the driving factors catalyzing the growth of the Indian motor automotive industry?**

Following the disruption caused by COVID, the automotive industry experienced downturns in the years that followed 2018. Now, after six years, the industry is back to normal. We are poised for better growth in almost all segments, and this is mainly driven by our government's focus on the manufacturing sector. The majority of tier-

one suppliers currently meet international quality standards, which is an encouraging sign when it comes to industry expansion. The introduction of chips into the automotive industry is also aiding the growth, not to mention how EVs are penetrating the market. With the road infrastructure getting better, the industry could maintain a steady pace for a decade going forward.

**How can effective leadership navigate and drive success in the evolving automotive landscape?**

Leadership, in my opinion, absorbs trends, predicts them, and equips organizations to handle them in the future. At the moment, leaders are concentrating on strengthening their respective organization's human capital, supporting customers through emerging technologies, developing customer centricity within the organization, and, in the process, leveraging their efforts to maintain appropriate cost structures. This will undoubtedly be their winning long-term strategy.

**What kinds of innovations are embraced by leaders today?**

Let's take the example of a car or bike, and we can notice a big difference in technologies used in the vehicle—even in the basic aspects like lighting. The electronics-powered lighting features are widely used in vehicles.

From telematics, cybersecurity to data analysis, cars are getting more computer-like features that look after drivers' safety while providing guidance in driving the car. Ultimately, it is becoming an interactive experience. These are the kinds of innovations embraced by organizations currently and, accordingly, nurturing talent to make those innovations into remarkable achievements.

**What has changed in the Indian automotive market today compared to the global market, and how does it impact the overall industry?**

Twenty years ago, importing the technology from the US and Europe to India was challenging. Today, the same technology can be brought from Europe, the US, and Japan all at the same time, thanks to the collective efforts of government initiatives and leaders' knowledge of bringing those technologies to customers. Also, there has been a change in customers' behavior—they are willing to spend money on purchasing these technologies. Now, we can see the same cycle of change happening in the automotive industry.

Today, exports are growing quickly as the automotive industry has learned to overcome the challenge of supplying quality products to international markets. Although many companies still have quality concerns, aggressive measures are being taken to ensure that they can deliver global quality in the market.

> *Indian roads will see new styles of cars with new looks and a different feel in aesthetics, especially from the Indian OEMs, which are very innovative and are bringing new looks to the SUV segmen*

**What are the best practices for nurturing young talent and fostering commitment in the team?**

Organizations must nurture the best talent. At the same time, these young talents must develop patience to implement what they have learned in their organization. Resources are abundant, but organizations must invest time and effort in cultivating these talents to stay stable in the growing market. As I mentioned before, young talents are hesitant to seek career opportunities in the manufacturing industry, which is considered to be a harder field than the software industry. I would say that only people who are actually interested can build a successful career in the manufacturing industry. People pursuing careers in the industry without sheer passion and inclination may lead to increasing attrition rates. As a result, the company's resources also get wasted. Hence, I suggest companies use psychometric tests or deeper analysis to filter the right talent and train them to better contribute to the organization.

**What key trends do you foresee in the Indian automotive industry in the next three to five years?**

EV penetration will continue, putting many manufacturers back into the drawing board. Indian roads will see new styles of cars with new looks and a different feel in aesthetics, especially from the Indian OEMs (Original Equipment Manufacturers), which are very innovative and are bringing new looks to the SUV segment. Although the penetration of the SUV segment may remain a bit stagnant in rural areas, it will continue to grow in urban areas. Thanks to EV penetration, there will also be daily commuting and last-mile connectivity through the commercial vehicle segment. This could lead to a reduction in the logistics cost, as there are many new players, both big and small, coming into the industry.



**Sankalp Potbhare**
MD & CEO - Asia Pacific & Japan
Versuni

**Sankalp Potbhare boasts over two decades of leadership in major consumer packaged goods (CPG) firms like PepsiCo, Reckitt Benckiser, Kraft, Heinz, and Kimberly Clark. Currently leading Versuni's (formerly Philips Domestic Appliances) operations in the Asia Pacific market, and Sankalp manages a multimillion- dollar portfolio. With extensive experience in diverse markets like China, Indonesia, Southeast Asia, Australia, and Korea, he adeptly navigates challenges and seizes opportunities. His typical day involves prioritizing tasks, morning meetings to address team challenges, and collaborating to provide solutions and strategic guidance.**

# TRANSFORMATIVE LEADERSHIP IN THE AGE OF AI AND CONSTANT CHANGE

If we see Sankalp's leadership style, he prioritizes proactive problem-solving and develops a collaborative environment to achieve organizational goals.

### Staying Abreast of Changing Market Dynamics

Sankalp views people management as vital in navigating today's dynamic landscape by providing clarity and purpose to the team. He values empowering individuals to embrace and navigate change effectively. Key methods for effective people management include articulating clear objectives to guide the team through ambiguity, ensuring everyone understands their role in achieving organizational goals. Furthermore, consistent communication can help in reinforcing priorities and expectations; thereby enabling effective task prioritization. Additionally, tailored support addresses diverse team needs which will progress towards shared goals.

And to top it off, Sankalp says that achieving results while demonstrating empathy is crucial. He stresses understanding and addressing individual needs to cultivate a supportive work environment. In his experience spanning various geographies, Sankalp has identified the following primary challenges that organizations encounter when crafting effective people management strategies:

One common challenge is maintaining consistency in communication and expectations. Teams often struggle when messages are unclear or continuously shifting. He emphasizes the importance of providing a clear and consistent message to keep teams focused and aligned with

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organizational objectives. Furthermore, another critical challenge can arise due to the alignment of organizational goals with individual goals. Here, there is a development of conflicting priorities which can lead to confusion and frustration among team members. Hence, Sankalp advocates on enabling collaboration by clearly articulating the 'what', 'how', and 'why' of tasks. This will ensure that individuals understand their role in contributing to the broader organizational objectives.

### Care & Empathy

"The significance of listening, empathy, and genuine care is a must for effective people management. Leaders must ensure that their messages are comprehended and resonate with team members. This can only happen when leaders understand the pulse from the ground. This will ultimately lead to a more supportive and productive work environment," Sankalp highlights.

### Reaping Benefits through the Integration of Disruptive Technologies

As the market evolves, it becomes more cumbersome for businesses to stay healthy. As we are slowly entering the world dominated by AI technologies, integration of this futuristic technology can bring significant changes when it comes to enhancing talent for effective management. Despite varied perspectives on AI's impact, be it positive or negative, today's management teams must recognize this disruptive technology's potential to revolutionize talent development within organizations.

Furthermore, AI offers personalized/ tailored learning and development plans by analyzing single individual or team-specific needs. This is far better than the obsolete practices that were being carried out previously. So to understand, management can ensure training programs align closely with employees' unique requirements by leveraging AI algorithms. AI facilitates standardized customer interactions across diverse teams. AI-driven solutions provide uniform communication frameworks, enhancing customer satisfaction and operational efficiency.

In functional domains like supply chain management, AI-driven predictive analytics refine forecasting processes which optimize inventory management and manufacturing operations. This not only enhances operational agility but also drives cost savings and organizational resilience. If we delve more deeply and look at an ever-changing work environment, organizations today face the challenge of navigating changing market dynamics. The evolution of work practices has been ongoing for decades and will continue to change as per the advancements in technologies and societal shifts.

> *Consistency in providing clarity enables teams to manage obstacles adeptly. Simplifying complex issues & articulating expectations clearly & with empathy fosters understanding among team members*

### Prioritizing Key Practices for Success

Leaders should adopt a mindset of 'welcoming change' for swift adaptation. Amid the pandemic, organizations transitioning rapidly to remote work exemplified this mindset and benefited as a result of the swift change. Open communication from leadership fosters understanding and alignment, wherein, addressing challenges openly empowers employees to contribute ideas. Cultivating a safe workplace encourages employees to voice concerns without fear. Here, trust is vital for fostering collaboration and innovation.

Delegating authority and promoting collaboration enables teams to adapt quickly while focusing towards ownership which fosters accountability and autonomy. Another important parameter is continuous learning, promoting a culture of learning ensures adaptability and skill retention. Furthermore, access to training programs keeps employees ahead in a changing landscape. When traditional feedback methods prove ineffective, it's crucial to reassess and adjust strategies. Here, leaders must focus on creating avenues for actionable feedback while also actively listening to the recipient's perspective. Additionally, leaders should deliver feedback genuinely to maintain trust and efficacy.

"One of the critical aspects of effective leadership lies in providing clarity, particularly during a disruptive market or organizational situation. A leader's ability to offer clear direction will greatly impact how their team overcomes challenging hurdles. Furthermore, a positive work culture with transparency in every operation can greatly enable teams to manage obstacles in the most adept way possible. Another important parameter would be to simplify complex issues while articulating expectations clearly; thereby fostering the needed understanding among team members," concludes Sankalp. CEO

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# DECIPHERING ZOMATO'S BUSINESS MODEL AND REVENUE STRATEGIES

BY ROOPALATHA H

Zomato is a well-known meal delivery and restaurant discovery website that has achieved impressive growth in the food business with great leadership & management by utilizing digital marketing tactics. Founded by Deepinder Goyal and Pankaj Chaddah, it began operating in 2008 and has since grown throughout the world, serving a wide range of users. Its success may be ascribed to its creative use of digital marketing strategies and Zomato's leadership team, which has strengthened user interaction, created a strong brand presence, and expanded its clientele.

## Delivering Delicious Happiness to the Doorstep

Zomato is unique in the industry because it provides foodies with an extensive platform to find and interact with restaurants. Its success is largely due to its user-friendly interface and the vast array of restaurants and cuisines it covers. Furthermore, the company has become a strong force in the meal delivery market. Similar to other businesses, the organization has grown significantly with the use of cutting-edge marketing techniques. Customers of all ages utilize the company's user-friendly food delivery app, which it has designed. Zomato's success story is only a result of the sophisticated tactics used by the company's experts.

## Zomato's Business Model

In the early days of the business, Zomato would scan restaurant menus and store them online, where users could access and view them. It continues to operate using the same concept but now offers additional services. Zomato's business model differs significantly from those of other meal delivery services. Uber and London & Partners are two of Zomato's main partners, and they may help the company debut in the UK on schedule.

Although the company's main asset is its extensive database of restaurants spread over 10,000 cities in 24 different countries, with the leadership of Goyal, the business strategy is focused on offering local restaurant search services, gathering information on contacts for food menus, and giving clients pertinent information. Zomato's primary platforms are its website and its mobile apps. Users searching for local eateries offering a variety of cuisines and eateries hoping to expand their brand recognition are the company's target market. Customers who prefer home delivery are also catered to by Zomato, which also assists with database and market research for businesses. Concurrently, the web-based platform is designed with an obligatory grading system. The food sector has seen a transformation because of Zomato's business strategy, which combines a variety of restaurants and makes it easy for customers to find eateries, leave reviews, and find listings that suit their preferred cuisine.

The organization employs people in more than 10,000 locales and conducts business in more than 24 countries. Due to its widespread visibility, Zomato has access to a big consumer base, which facilitates the company's ability to grow its clientele and offer more services. Additionally, it has given the business a competitive advantage over its rivals by enabling it to serve a variety of cultures and cuisines. Zomato's most recent annual report states that the company has 32.1 million active monthly users. The business has made calculated investments and acquisitions in a number of areas, most notably the 2020 acquisition of Uber Eats India. Additionally, the company's ability to collaborate

with other businesses and brands has been facilitated by its wide reach.

### Zomato's Footprint in Online Grocery Delivery

An app for ordering and delivering takeaway online under the name 'Zomato Market,' Zomato has entered the grocery delivery market, promising to deliver and hoping to capitalize on the increased demand for these services. Zomato's entry into the grocery market coincides with a period of rapid order volume growth for online grocery stores, primarily as a result of the government's stringent implementation of instructions to stay at home in order to maintain social norms.

> *WHEN THINGS REACHED A BREAKING POINT IN 2016, ZOMATO WAS FORCED TO HALT OPERATIONS IN A NUMBER OF NATIONS, INCLUDING THE US, UK, BRAZIL, CHILE, SRI LANKA, CANADA, ITALY, SLOVAKIA, AND IRELAND. ADDITIONALLY, ZOMATO HAD TO USE REMOTE SERVICES WHEN IT EVENTUALLY STARTED OPERATING AGAIN IN THE AFOREMENTIONED NATIONS*

### weatherunion.com. by Zomato

Zomato announced India's first crowd-supported weather infrastructure to offer localized, up-to-date information on important meteorological factors like temperature, humidity, wind speed, rainfall, and more. It is a proprietary network of more than 650 ground-based weather stations that goes by the name weatherunion.com. At present, it is accessible in 45 locations, and the firm has said that it will shortly be extending to additional cities.

"At Zomato, it was crucial for us to have access to precise and real-time weather information to make the right business decisions to serve our customers better. Hence, we took it upon ourselves to develop a solution capable of empowering us on this front. This rich data holds significant potential in unlocking weather use cases for enterprises and research institutes. Having already collaborated with CAS – IIT Delhi, we expect more institutions and companies to benefit from this and contribute towards the greater good of our economy," says Goyal.

### Challenges Faced

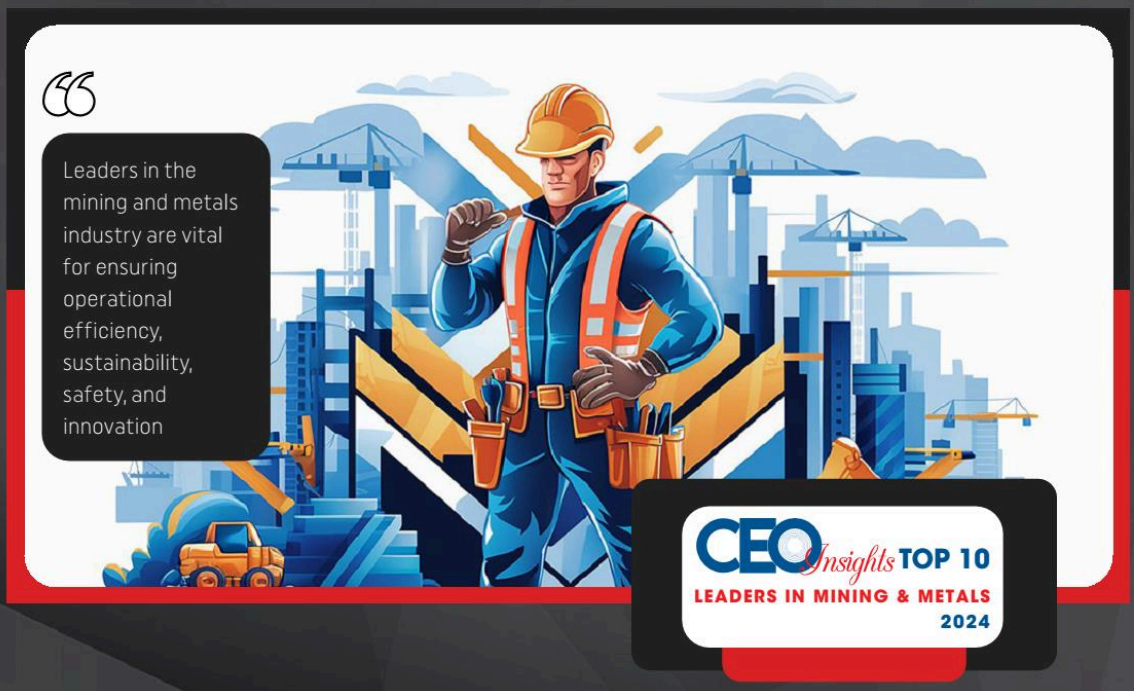
The Zomato graph, which is looking great so far, changed after 2014. Due to various challenges that the company faced in 2015, some difficult decisions had to be made. After purchasing Urbanspoon and rebranding it as its own, the business performed so badly that the corporation had to fire 300 workers—10 percent of whom were US citizens—to reduce losses.

Their narrative has more in store. When a cyberattack threatened Zomato's continued existence in 2017, the company suffered a severe setback. A hacker had gained access to 17 million users' records from the company's database. Zomato quickly realized that the hacker was the only one with access to the data, and after speaking with the hacker, the breach was fixed.

As a result, in 2019, a movement known as #logout emerged, in which participating restaurants blasted the firm for allegedly eating into their profit margins through services like Zomato Gold and Infinity Dining, which gave users steep discounts. Following significant opposition from its affiliated eateries and internal staff reductions, Zomato terminated its Infinity dining offering and changed the Zomato Gold guidelines, causing the issue to eventually fade.

But despite all, Zomato's essence endures, as its slogan, 'Never have a bad meal,' perfectly captures. The cherry on top is that Zomato added 73K new eateries and saw a 177 percent increase in its restaurant partners.

Zomato's distinct and enduring business and revenue model and a clearly defined organizational framework have enabled the company to maintain its position as a leading player in the industry. Because of its assortment, affordability, and ease of use, Zomato has achieved success and gained its customers' trust over the years. CEO




## Empowering Progress through Responsible Mining

Leadership in the mining and metals industry is crucial for several reasons, including operational efficiency, sustainability, safety, and innovation. Effective leaders in this sector ensure that operations are optimized, which enhances productivity and profitability. Their role in navigating the complex challenges of the industry and guiding it towards a sustainable and profitable future cannot be overstated. They are essential in steering companies towards sustainable practices. They play a pivotal role in developing strategies that streamline processes, reduce costs, and maximize output.

### Setting New Standards in Mining Leadership

The mining and metals industry has significant environmental impacts, and strong leadership is required to implement and adhere to sustainable mining practices. This includes managing waste, reducing emissions, and ensuring that mining operations do not irreparably damage ecosystems. Leaders advocate for and oversee the adoption of environmentally friendly technologies and practices, which are crucial for the industry's long-term viability and for meeting regulatory and societal expectations. The mining industry is inherently hazardous, and effective leaders prioritize the health and safety of their workers. They establish rigorous safety protocols, invest in training, and foster a culture of safety that minimizes accidents and health risks. By promoting a safe working environment, leaders not only protect their workforce but also enhance operational stability and reduce downtime associated with accidents. Innovation is also driven by strong leadership. The mining and metals sector faces numerous challenges, including ore depletion, market volatility, and the need for more efficient extraction methods. Visionary leaders drive research and development efforts, encouraging the adoption of cutting-edge technologies such as automation, digitalization, and advanced material science. These innovations can lead to more efficient and cost-effective operations, positioning companies to better compete in the global market.

**CEO Insights** in this issue presents a list of '**Top 10 Leaders in Mining & Metals - 2024**' who have leveraged their extensive industry expertise and experience in offering effective skills to the market. The following list has been prepared after being closely scrutinized by a distinguished panel of judges including CXOs, analysts and our editorial board. We recognize their valuable contribution to the ever expanding and competitive market and their ability to sustain themselves and emerge as top contestants through their reliable knowledge.

# TOP 10 LEADERS IN MINING & METALS - 2024

## ANUJ BAREJA
FOUNDER

Asier Metals
Mumbai
asier.in

With a proven track record of expertise in metallurgic trading, operations management, research and development, technical marketing, and cross-functional team leadership

## MANISH BHATI
DIRECTOR & INVESTOR

Allied Mining
Nagpur
alliedmining.in

Possessing a background in the Indian and Australian underground mining sector, proficient in negotiation, strategic planning, business development, management, and business strategy

## MONICA BACHCHAN DUVVURI
FOUNDER & ENTREPRENEUR

Metalogic PMS
Gautam Buddha Nagar
metalogicpms.com

Having extensive experience in the steel and mining industry, also proficient in marketing, PR, sales, business development, negotiation, mining and product development

## SANJEEV DAS
FOUNDER & DIRECTOR

MineMagma
Bangalore
minemagma.com

He has specializes in team management, business strategy, management, project management, legal, procurement and green field linear and non-linear projects

## SUBHRAKANT PANDA
MANAGING DIRECTOR

Indian Metals & Ferro Alloys
Bhubaneswar
imfa.in

With his experience in finance and operations management, also excels in business development, operation management, change management, finance and leadership

## KARMAN DANGAR
OWNER

HRD Group of Companies
Bhuj
hrdgroup.in

He has a diverse educational background and highlights the integration of local resources with global technology as a key factor for success in the mining sector

## MANISH R DOSH
MANAGING DIRECTOR & CEO

Galena Metals
Mumbai
galenametals.com

He uses economic trends and industry shifts to identify investment opportunities, leveraging his expertise in finance, strategy, and international affairs to elevate the firm's global reputation

## RONAK MODI
MANAGING PARTNER

Shreeji Steel Tubes
Mumbai
shreejisteeltubes.com

He is a driven entrepreneur with a strong background in business development and strategic planning and he plays key roles in monitoring the team's performance

## SOHAM BATHWAL
MANAGING DIRECTOR

Bathwal Corporation
Kolkata
bathwalcorp.com

Expertise in managing and expanding the steel plant, diversifying product portfolio to include iron ore pellets and specialty wire products for the automotive and construction industries in India

## VIJAY ATREYA
CO-FOUNDER & CEO

Metal Mates
Jalna
metalmates.in

Commitment to innovation and digital transformation with his expertise lies M&A, sourcing consultancy, international trading support, company valuations, and policy matters



# KARMAN DANGAR

## UNVEILING THE PATH OF MINING TRANSFORMATION THROUGH INNOVATIVE LEADERSHIP

**KARMAN DANGAR**
**OWNER**
**HRD GROUP OF COMPANIES**

Karman Dangar, owner of the HRD Group of Companies, blends eight years of business acumen with a diverse educational background, having graduated from Rajkot and London. His visionary leadership drives the company's success, emphasizing the fusion of local resources with global technology to excel in the mining industry.

> As a cohesive entity within the HRD Group of Companies, we've ascended to the forefront as the primary manufacturers of kaolin & silica sand within our industry

In the dynamic realm of the mining industry, an efficient leader holds a paramount importance navigating challenges and capitalizing on opportunities. At its core, effective leadership entails striking a delicate balance between leveraging cutting-edge technology and honoring traditional values. Karman Dangar, at the helm of the HRD Group of Companies, epitomizes this philosophy. Influenced by his grandfather's visionary approach and values, Karman embarked on a journey to expand the family business upon completing his post-graduation in the UK. Under his stewardship, the HRD Group has diversified its operations, specializing in the lavigation, beneficiation, and calcination of Kaolin and silica sand. Moreover, Karman's strategic vision has led to the inclusion of additional minerals such as quartz, ball clay, salt, and laterite, broadening the company's scope and solidifying its position as a leader in the industry. Through a blend of tradition and innovation, Karman continues to steer the HRD Group towards unprecedented success. Let's read on.

**Share insights into some of the technological and scientific research advancements that have bolstered the HRD Group's market position under your leadership?**

Our ascendancy to the top spot in production capacity within our industry hinges on technological and scientific advancements. Upon joining the business in 2016-17, our inability to utilize 45-50 percent of materials due to inadequate technology and infrastructure hindered resource optimization. However, after 18 months of rigorous research and global exploration to benchmark industry practices, we pioneered the implementation of innovative technology. This adoption substantially reduced material loss from 45-50 percent to a mere five percent. Notably, our initiative has inspired approximately 100 small to medium-sized

enterprises to emulate our approach, reaping the benefits of advanced technologies.

**Under your leadership, how have production capabilities been augmented? Would you be willing to outline some strategies employed to achieve this enhancement?**

During my tenure, our production capabilities have undergone a substantial boost. As a cohesive entity within the HRD Group of Companies, we've ascended to the forefront as the primary manufacturers of Kaolin and silica sand within our industry, surpassing our former seventh place standing. Our relentless efforts persist as we strive to not only sustain this achievement but also to secure the leading position across various other mineral sectors, driving our company's growth and prominence in the market.

**How do you ensure the workforce remains motivated to contribute to the success of the business?**

I believe our growth is attributed to the philosophy instilled by our company's Founder, Rana Rava Dangar. He emphasized viewing individuals not merely as employees or laborers, but as partners. Upholding this ethos, we incentivize dedicated individuals who have served for 8-10 years by offering them partnership in our business. This approach fosters a sense of ownership and loyalty; hence, those who have been with us for this duration never depart as mere employees but as valued partners.

**What is your anticipation about the market and your future vision for the group, and how do you plan to execute it?**

I am very bullish on our Indian economy and the forthcoming future of our company. We feel our company have just arrived in this and it's the time to accelerate in terms of expanding as we all know our country will be growing at significant speed under the leadership of our honourable prime minister Narendra Modi. Because of his vision, the industries in which we are working and supplying directly such as solar glass, cement, ceramic, paint and more, will be growing at incredible speed. As I mentioned earlier that there many key infrastructure industries which will be growing at very big scale, we as HRD Group would try to make sure that Indian



industries get all the necessary world class quality minerals locally itself. For example, we believe solar glass manufacturers will require huge amount of silica sand with the best quality but as of now we had to import those quality sand from Egypt and other countries but after four years of research we have finally achieved the same quality with only 40 percent cost. Hence, if we can have all the resources locally then it would much better for our industries to compete at world level.

**Given your robust professional background in the industry, what guidance would you offer to emerging leaders in the field?**

In the realm of mining, success hinges on your ability to bridge the gap between the resources present on your land and the latest global technological and innovative trends. By adeptly harnessing and optimizing your minerals, you position yourself for success, especially considering the significant growth opportunities our country currently offers. Understanding how to leverage advancements in technology and innovation to enhance your mineral output is paramount in capitalizing on the burgeoning prospects within our industry.



**Sriraman Raghunathan**
Head & Chief Architect
Marlabs

**With over 20 years of experience, Sriraman is a seasoned leader in digital innovation, emerging tech, and sustainability. He spearheads Marlab's innovation, tech solutions, revenue, and ESG integration. In a recent interaction with CEO Insights, he emphasized a leadership approach advocating for strategic vision, commitment, a culture of risk-taking, and autonomy to foster innovation and AI adoption. Below are the excerpts of the interaction.**

# MANAGING AI INTEGRATION, EMPLOYEE UPSKILLING FOR CHANGE ENVIRONMENT

**How can leaders foster a culture of innovation to encourage experimentation and adoption of AI and ML technologies?**

This requires a multipronged approach that combines broader strategic vision, organizational leadership commitment and support, nurturing the right mindset among team members and culture and environment to support it. Leadership should lead by example, by adopting AI themselves and they should commit capital, both financial and human, to lead and drive specific AI innovation initiatives. This could include funding for R&D, dedicated teams for AI projects and access to training and learning programs. A key attribute of experimentation is encouraging risk taking by creating an environment where failure is seen as learning opportunities. Lastly, organizations should provide autonomy by giving employees the freedom to explore new ideas and empower them to make decisions and take ownership of their work, which can increase motivation and creativity.

**How can leaders effectively manage the change management process associated with AI integration, including addressing employee concerns and upskilling?**

Effectively managing the change management process associated with AI integration involves a combination of strategic planning, clear communication, empathy, and proactive upskilling initiatives. Clearly communicating the impact of AI on the organization's vision and its benefits helps employees understand the purpose behind the change and reduces uncertainty. Leaders should openly acknowledge and address

employees' concerns about AI integration, provide reassurance, offer training and upskilling programs (both technical and soft skills), and emphasize the ways AI can enhance, rather than replace, their roles and responsibilities. Organizations should involve their employees in the AI integration process from the beginning, incorporate their inputs and feedback, and encourage them to participate in pilot programs, fostering a sense of ownership.

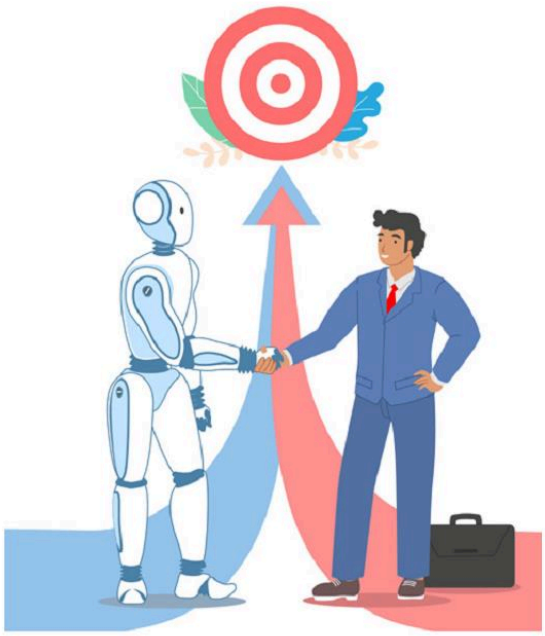
**What steps can organizations take to attract and retain top data talent in a competitive market?**

Companies face a constant challenge in attracting talent, especially in AI, due to rising costs of hiring, skill gaps and more importantly, for larger companies there are competitive pressures from the start-up ecosystem. Some approaches to address these include upskilling existing talent pools within the organization, better compensation structure to those who become AI-ready, partnerships with academia to set up incubators and COEs leading to collaborative initiatives, shared IPs, with a path to hiring academic talent contributing to these initiatives. Further it is also important for organizations to create a cultural environment that fosters creativity and innovation, commit investments into AI-led initiatives and assure higher quality of work and purpose.

*Organizations should involve their employees in the AI integration process from the beginning, incorporate their inputs & feedback, & encourage them to participate in pilot programs, fostering a sense of ownership*

**What are some effective strategies for identifying and developing the necessary AI skills among employees?**

Some approaches to effectively execute this strategy include identifying skill gaps and areas where upskilling is needed to support AI initiatives, defining clear learning objectives aligned with the organization's AI strategy and a comprehensive supporting curriculum, flexible training methods, hands-on experience with supporting infrastructure and a system of recognition and rewards, monitoring progress of learning KPIs and measuring its business impact. Executing this strategy also requires strong leadership support, adequate resources, and a commitment to investing in upskilling of employees and fostering a culture of innovation and learning.



**What trends do you foresee shaping the AI landscape in the next 3-5 years?**

Some of the trends include increased regulation and oversight leading to advancements on ethical AI with a growing emphasis on developing and deploying AI in an ethical and responsible manner. This includes addressing issues such as bias, fairness, transparency, and accountability in AI algorithms and systems. AI tools and platforms will also become more accessible to a wider range of users, including those without extensive technical expertise. This democratization of AI will empower individuals and organizations to leverage AI technologies for various applications, fueling innovation and economic growth. Also, AI models will move closer to the edge, reducing latency, improving privacy and security, and operating in environments with limited connectivity.



# RONAK MODI

## A PASSIONATE LEADER DELIVERING VALUE VIA QUALITY STEEL TUBES

'Success is not final; failure is not fatal: It is the courage to continue that count' - Winston Churchill. This quote resonates deeply with Ronak Modi—Managing Partner of Shreeji Steel Tubes—who grew up witnessing the entrepreneurial journey of his father and uncle. Seeing them overcome challenges and build successful businesses fueled Ronak's entrepreneurial aspirations. Inspired by their determination and resilience, Ronak embarked on his own venture, determined to make a mark in the business world. In 2011, after accumulating significant experience, Ronak launched Shreeji Steel Tubes, which specializes in steel tubes within the metal industries. Today, Shreeji Steel Tubes is one of the leading distributors, stockiest, and supplier of Iron & Steel products. I also thank my father's business associates from the same industry, who shaped my ideas since childhood. Circa 2024 – I am driven by a vision to be a quality driven steel tubes behemoth whom my customers can trust!!

In this interview with CEO Insights, Ronak shares insights into his entrepreneurial journey and highlights his personal experience.

**How would you define Shreeji Steel Tubes as an organization and where it's positioned in today's market?**

Shreeji Steel Tubes is an ISO 9001:2015 certified company based in Mumbai. We are known for a widest range of superior quality steel tubes, affirming our reputation as the House of Quality Steel Tubes. Our commitment to meeting customer needs under one roof is evident in our extensive range of steel tubes, including GI, MS, and GP ERW Round Pipe, Structural Hollow Sections (Circular (CHS), Square (SHS), and Rectangular (RHS) in all steel grades YST210/YST240/

**RONAK MODI**
**MANAGING PARTNER**
**SHREEJI STEEL TUBES**

Ronak Modi is a driven entrepreneur with a strong background in business development and strategic planning. His leadership style is characterized by a focus on innovation, quality, and ethical practices.

> Our vision is to establish a presence at a national level, ensuring that customers who value quality & variety of products are drawn to us through our reputation & positive word of mouth

- **Hobbies:** *Traveller, Music, Photography, Movies, Sports*
- **Favorite Cuisine:** *Indian, Asian, Italian*
- **Favorite Book:** *The Monk who Sold Ferrari, Zero to One*
- **Favorite Travel Destination:** *London, Los Angeles*

YST310/YST355), Seamless Pipes, Spiral Welded Pipes, and other MS/Galvanized Steel products, available in all sizes.

With a vast storage capacity spanning approximately 84,000 square feet in Kalamboli, a key steel market hub in Maharashtra, we are uniquely positioned to deliver high-quality products in desired sizes and quantities not only in Mumbai and Maharashtra but also across major regions in India. Our large customer base and strategic approach to product acquisition have enabled us to build a loyal customer portfolio.

### How do you approach leadership, and what values characterize your leadership style?

My approach to leadership has evolved over time. Initially, I was very hands-on, trying to handle everything myself without delegating enough. However, as the company has grown significantly, I've come to realize the importance of having a strong team. I have started delegating tasks and have already implemented a team structure. Additionally, I have the support of my active father and my wife, who manage the accounts. They play key roles in monitoring the team's performance. Moving forward, we plan to further professionalize the team by appointing domain experts to manage different functions.

### How do you stay updated with the latest industry trends?

In our industry, staying updated with the latest trends is a continuous effort that revolves around effective networking. Networking plays a crucial role as it allows us to connect with key players, stay informed about market dynamics, and anticipate upcoming trends. As a company associated with top brands in India, maintaining strong networks is essential for us to remain competitive and relevant in the industry.

Our years of experience and established reputation have positioned us well to leverage these networks effectively. We actively engage with industry experts, attend relevant conferences and seminars, and keep a close eye on market developments. This proactive approach enables us to not only stay informed about current trends but also anticipate future shifts in consumer preferences, technology advancements, and regulatory changes.

Being at the forefront of our industry means being adaptable and responsive to changes. We are confident in our ability to adapt quickly to emerging trends, innovate our product line, and maintain our position as a leader in the market. This commitment to staying updated and leveraging our networks ensures that we continue to meet the evolving needs of our customers and drive growth in our business.

### What are your goals and future aspirations for the next five years?

Currently, we are experiencing significant growth, driven by our efforts and vision. We believe this growth trajectory will lead us to new opportunities and milestones in the business. One of our primary objectives in the coming years is to reach every customer segment across India, expanding beyond our current base in Mumbai and the western region. Our vision is to establish a presence at a national level, ensuring that customers who value quality and variety of products are drawn to us through our reputation and positive word of mouth.

We take pride in our company's commitment to ethics and principles, valuing customer input and embodying a culture of quality in everything we do. Our company's tagline, 'House of Quality Steel Tubes,' reflects this ethos. As we look at our current standing, we are eager for growth, fueled by India's ongoing economic expansion. Our goal is to double our product (SKU) range in the steel tubes & steel category in the coming years.

### Drawing from your extensive experience in the mining and metal industry, what advice would you give to future leaders entering this domain?

My advice for future leaders entering the mining and metal industry is rooted in foundational principles. Firstly, there's no replacement for hard work; it forms the core of success in this field. Having a clear vision is crucial, as it guides your actions and decisions while upholding ethical standards under all circumstances.

Another key aspect is never compromising on quality. Quality is not just a standard; it's a commitment that builds trust with stakeholders and ensures long-term success. Finally, always prioritize ethics and principles. These values are the backbone of sustainable business practices and contribute to earning respect and credibility in the industry. CEO



**Dr. Debojyoti Dhar**
Co-Founder & Director
Leucine Rich Bio

**With over 10 years of expertise in both academic and corporate "research and development" (R&D) operations, Dr. Debojyoti Dhar, PhD (Indian Institute of Science, IISc) possesses significant multi-domain knowledge in the pharmaceutical and biotechnology industries. During his PhD studies at the Indian Institute of Science (IISc) and post-doctoral study at UMass Medical School (USA), he conducted a great deal of research on translational modulation of gene regulation. Additionally, Dr. Dhar has worked at the Indian drug development business Connexios Life Sciences on diabetes and metabolic syndrome.**

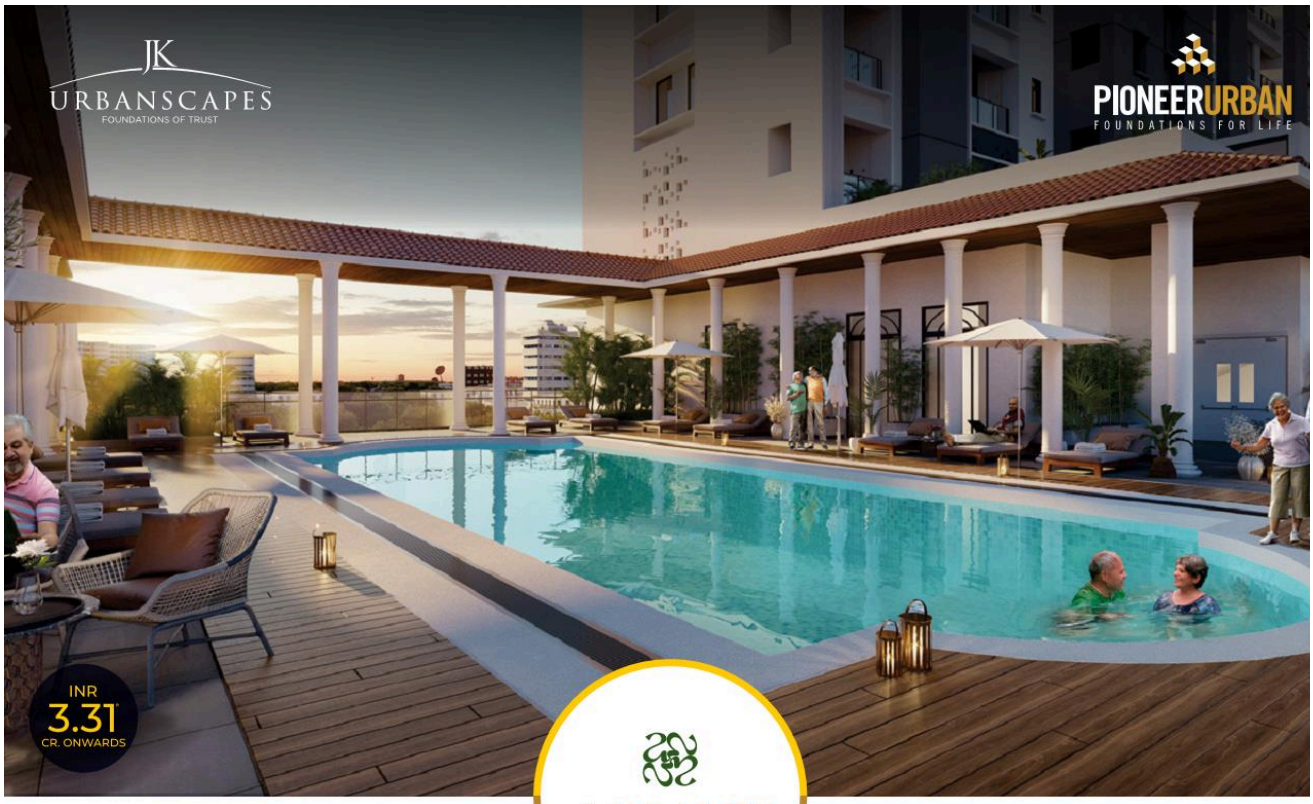
# MICROBIOME IN DRUG DEVELOPMENT: TECHNOLOGICALLY ADVANCING PRECISION MEDICINE

The human microbiome, a complex community of trillions of microorganisms primarily residing in the gut, plays a crucial role in health and disease. Its influence extends to various physiological processes, including metabolism, immune function, and neurological health. Recognizing this, researchers and pharmaceutical companies are increasingly exploring microbiome's potential in drug development.

Advances in metagenomics and bioinformatics allow us to identify microbial biomarkers that can predict responses to drugs. These biomarkers enable the development of more effective and targeted therapies. The microbiome influences drug metabolism, impacting efficacy and safety. By understanding these interactions, we can design drugs with better efficacy profiles and fewer side effects.

Live biotherapeutic products (LBPs), derived from beneficial microbes, represent a novel class of treatments. These therapies are being developed for conditions ranging from gastrointestinal disorders to cancer. In fact, the US FDA has recently approved two new microbiome based drugs REBYOTA (Ferring pharma) and VOWST (SERES therapeutics) for treating recurrent Clostridium infections. Microbiome profiling facilitates personalized medicine by tailoring treatments to an individual's unique microbial composition. This approach promises improved outcomes and reduced adverse effects.

Innovations in sequencing technologies have drastically reduced costs and increased the accuracy of microbiome analysis. This enables




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large-scale studies and the generation of vast datasets critical for drug discovery.

> *The future of medicine lies in our ability to understand and manipulate the microbiome, unlocking new potentials in disease prevention & treatment*

AI and machine learning algorithms are revolutionizing microbiome research by enabling the analysis of complex data. These technologies help identify patterns and predict therapeutic outcomes. Metabolomic profiling of the microbiome provides insights into metabolic interactions between microbes and their human hosts. This information is vital for understanding disease mechanisms and developing targeted therapies.

According to the National Cancer Institute (NCI), the gut microbiome can influence the efficacy of immunotherapy in cancer patients. Specific bacterial strains have been identified that enhance the response to checkpoint inhibitors, leading to more effective treatments. Microbiome-based interventions are showing promise in treating conditions like inflammatory bowel disease (IBD) and irritable bowel syndrome (IBS). Probiotics, prebiotics, and fecal microbiota transplants are being explored as therapeutic options.

The microbiome's role in metabolic health is a burgeoning area of research. Studies are investigating how microbial composition affects conditions like obesity and diabetes, paving the way for microbiome-targeted therapies.

The integration of microbiome research into drug development marks a transformative shift towards precision medicine. At Leucine Rich Bio, we are committed to leveraging these technological advances to develop innovative healthcare solutions that improve patient outcomes. The future of medicine lies in our ability to understand and manipulate the microbiome, unlocking new potentials in disease prevention and treatment. CEO

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# THE ADVANTAGES OF BRANDS UTILIZING MULTIPLE WAREHOUSES



**By Dr. Ashvini Jakhar,** Founder & CEO, Prozo

**With over two decades of experience in the supply chain tech industry, Ashvini, a former Indian Navy and McKinsey professional, holds a strong belief in curing the complexities of supply chains. He isan alumnus of ISB and Armed Forces Medical College, Pune.**

As brands continue to grow and expand their operations, one crucial question often arises: When should they consider operating from multiple warehouses? This question becomes increasingly prominent as brands evolve from handling 500 orders a day to managing 1500 orders a day and beyond. The decision to expand to multiple warehouses is significant, influenced by various factors that can shape a brand's long-term success. Let us examine the key considerations that brands should contemplate when making this strategic move:

### The Threshold for Expansion

While there is no one-size-fits-all answer, my experience suggests that once a brand reaches around a thousand orders a day, it is a prime opportunity to consider expanding to multiple warehouses. The first crucial decision to consider after this is, how many additional warehouses to establish? Brands must weigh the options carefully, deciding whether to extend operations by just one additional warehouse, or expand across multiple geographic regions, such as east, west, north, and south. The choice depends on various factors that include product diversity, customer distribution, and the potential for business growth in those regions.

### Key Decision-Making Parameters

1. SKU Diversity: Brands should assess whether their products are concentrated around a few 'hero' SKUs or distributed evenly across their catalog. This evaluation can influence the choice of warehouse locations.
2. Supply Chain Partners: Compatibility with supply chain partners and the adaptability of existing tech systems are critical factors. Choosing a new geographic region with inadequate support can complicate expansion efforts.
3. Clear Objectives: Brands should define their objectives for expanding to new territories. Is the goal to offer faster deliveries to customers, tap into strategic markets, or both? Clear objectives help in evaluating the success of the expansion.
4. Cost Savings: Expanding to multiple warehouses can lead to cost savings. Brands must consider the potential reduction in logistics costs due to increased local and regional deliveries, which can boost profitability.

### Inventory Planning

Effective inventory planning is crucial when operating multiple warehouses. Brands typically begin with 30 to 60 days of inventory, depending on SKU distribution. Intelligent inventory replenishment tools can help determine the optimal inventory levels for each warehouse. This process should be ongoing, with regular adjustments based on demand patterns.

### Reverse Logistics

Brands must also address the reverse logistics journey, considering returns and product movements from customers to the warehouse and between regional warehouses. Addressing this early in the growth journey is essential to maintaining operational efficiency.

### Multi-Channel Operations

Last but not the least, successful brands leverage multi-channel operations from their regional warehouses. This means processing not only D2C orders but also B2B and marketplace orders from a single inventory pool. Making this strategic decision can enhance operational flexibility and revenue potential.

### Conclusion

Expanding to multiple warehouses is a crucial decision for brands experiencing growth. When executed strategically, it can lead to improved customer service, cost savings, and enhanced revenue opportunities. Brands should carefully evaluate their circumstances, considering factors such as SKU diversity, supply chain partnerships, and have clear objectives. Effective inventory planning, reverse logistics management, and the implementation of multi-channel operations are essential elements of a successful expansion strategy. As you embark on your journey to expand to new warehouses, consider partnering with a provider that has warehouses across the country and a comprehensive technology stack to streamline your operations. This will ensure you have a successful growth journey as you explore the potential of operating multiple warehouses in today's dynamic business landscape. CEO


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**Our solutions deliver real time insights that banks need to succeed in today's dynamic business environment. Leading banks across Asia, Africa and the Middle East have partnered with Sunoida to uncover new ways to drive profitability using the power of their own data.**

### Vision Revenue Assurance

Helps banks prevent income leakage and turn revenue leaks across the customer engagement lifecycle into profits.

### Vision Banking BI

Uses customer data to optimize business performance and deliver enhanced visibility and control.

### Vision Central Bank ADF & BI

Delivers automated daily insights into the entire country's financial sector using our ground-breaking ADF technology.

For more information mail us at **marketing@sunoida.com**

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